

teams using the brand to suggest they were part of the success, without them actually practising the values of IS.

Worse, business units may simply claim they “do InnerSource” but not make the effort that is required (<https://www.oreilly.com/library/view/adopting-innersource/9781492041863/>).

Gamification can come to the rescue.

Something like an InnerSource premier league can be organised, where the scoreboard is updated daily with teams or individuals getting scores for their contributions like development, mentorship, evangelization, testing, etc. Such real-time tracking of efforts can thwart any attempts at IS brand dilution or false claims of contribution.

Addressing individual challenges

Unwillingness to mentor

Mentoring in IS projects is intended to help new joiners (with respect to the IS project) learn the basics of IS along with the culture and process of collaborative development, realise its benefits, and overcome barriers to contribution. Mentoring is thus a crucial element for the success of an IS project. However, often due to intense time pressures such mentorship takes a hit. For example, it is observed that mentoring is the first to get affected in a situation of impending deadlines as people either fail to realise its importance or think of it as a thankless job.

Organisations should encourage mentorship through rewards, points, and leaderboards, and add it as a component of the InnerSource goals discussed earlier in the article.

Not invented here

‘Not invented here’ (NIH) is a suspicion many software developers have about the quality and maintainability of any software they didn’t personally write. Such suspicion often manifests as a misplaced perception that the IS software, which

is usually developed by multiple teams, is of sub-standard quality.

Companies can avoid this challenge by developing a mechanism to standardise the software and its components. For example, code quality can be scored based on its size, reliability, maintainability, efficiency, and security. For IS contributions, the code should be above a minimum threshold score

This can help address trust issues as well as ease the on-boarding process for developers new to the IS project. Also, it’s good to add a goal for documentation. Good documentation helps to reduce NIH suspicions.

Summing it up

InnerSource (IS) adoption brings numerous benefits for software

organisations. However, as with any change program, IS has its share of challenges. Organisations planning to walk the IS path need to be aware of the challenges that might come their way.

Involve different organisational units—including HR—when working to understand the challenges, formulate policies to address them, and develop a culture suited for IS adoption. With collaborative brainstorming that includes all the stakeholders and business units, the recommendations in this article can form a basis for tackling the unique challenges you’re facing in your organisation.

This approach not only helps to manage the IS challenges, but also to build the inclusive and collaborative organisation that is one of the signs of IS success. **END** 

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- Adopting InnerSource by Danese Cooper, Klaas-Jan Stol released September 2018 Publisher(s): O'Reilly Media, Inc. ISBN: 9781492041856, <https://www.oreilly.com/library/view/adopting-innersource/9781492041863/>

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